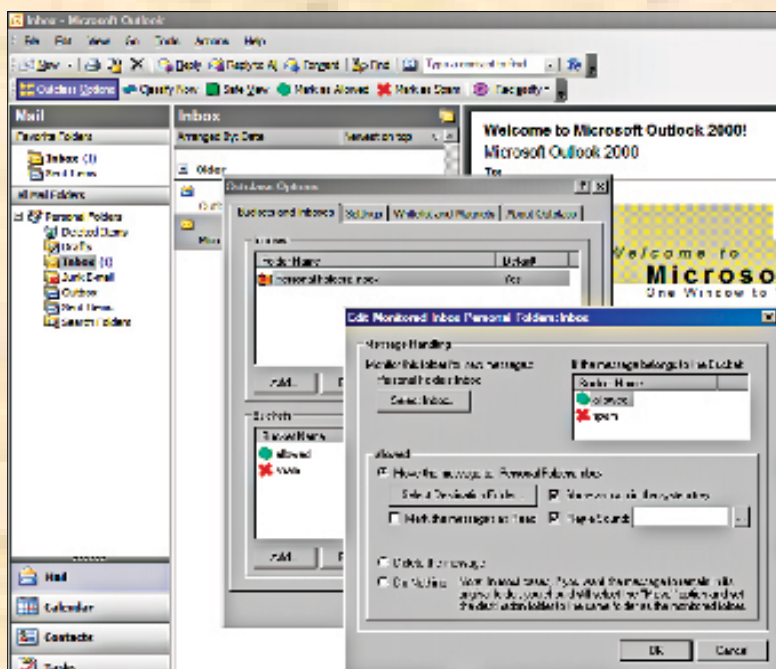


the first time, it's like this: say you want mails from your (two) siblings to go into a folder called Family. You tell Outlook that if an incoming mail has either of their e-mail addresses in the "Sender" field, it should automatically divert it into the Family folder instead of sending it to the Inbox. That becomes a Rule for Outlook. Similarly, if you want to be alerted with a sound when there's a mail from your boss, you could tell Outlook about that, too. Moreover, it's not limited to the "From" field – Rules could be based on a whole bunch of parameters, such as what time they arrive, whether they have attachments, whether there are certain words in the subject line, and so on.

To use the Wizard, go to Tools > Rules and Alerts, and in the E-mail Rules tab, click New Rule. You'll then have the option of going with the provided Templates or to "Start from a blank rule". Let's look at what happens when you start from a blank rule and choose to "Check mes-



Define actions here

sages when they arrive" (which is the first thing you'll need to select).

It's pretty intuitive. As you select your conditions in the top part of the Rules Wizard window, your Rule gets "built up" in the bottom part. So if you select "with specific words in the subject", those words will appear below – and you click on the words "specific words" to define those words.

Be sure to go through all the options you're provided with under the conditions to be checked for – for example, all mail where your name is not in the “To” box could be sent to a special folder, which you might want to examine only once a day. Then, when you're done creating the rule, you could choose to run it on all messages in your Inbox right then – do that and watch all your mails make their way to the right place! (Assuming, of course, that you've set up the appropriate folders.)

The Clean Inbox, #2

POPFile, many have been saying for years, is the best spam filter there is. It needs to be trained to recognise spam, but it gets trained pretty quickly (if you receive a respectable number of e-mails). Now POPFile as it is can be a little off-putting in terms of the user interface, but there's Outclass, a little program (which works when POPFile is installed) that integrates with Outlook as a toolbar.

Space doesn't permit a complete discussion of how to use the Outclass toolbar. We'll point out and clarify a few things here; the easy-to-follow (with screenshots) documentation is at www.vargonsoft.com/Outclass/release-1.2.4.1.aspx. Outclass hasn't been tested by the developers to work with Outlook 2007, but it does, it seems.

Outclass isn't just for spam filtering – the idea is called “buckets,” which you can think of as imaginary folders. Say you define three buckets – Work, Personal, and Spam. Outclass doesn't know that “Spam” is some kind of evil thing; when it “reads” a message, it decides what bucket it belongs in, depending on how it's been trained. It can then route the contents of the buckets to appropriate folders as you've defined.

In case you're wondering what "training" is about: just after Outclass has been installed and a mail comes in, it's marked as "Unclassified". You use the buttons on the toolbar to classify it as Personal, Work, or Spam. The act of doing this for many messages is called training... simple enough.

There's a useful feature on the default toolbar, called "Safe View". Some spam contains "Web bugs," which means that if you open it by mistake, you could send out a confirmation to the spammer that yours is an operational e-mail address. When you choose to view a potential spam message using the "Safe View" button, you'll view it without triggering the "Web bug."

At the left of the Outclass toolbar is the Outclass Options button; in the options dialog, the first tab is Buckets and Inboxes. “Inboxes” refers to the Outlook folders to be monitored; refer to the documentation for this. The Buckets are the categories. You can define as many buckets as you want, choose whether the button (to classify mail into a certain bucket) should be on the toolbar, and what its name should be.

When you click on the Inbox and then on Edit, you'll get a dialog where you can specify what should be done to a message depending on which Bucket Outclass puts it into.

Remember...

You could go with Rules, or you could let Outclass automatically classify mails for you. You might want to do the latter if there are too many unspecified people who send you mail. If you have a large network of connections, you'll often get mail from people you don't know, and if the only classification you need is, say, into Personal, Work, and Newsletters (apart from Spam), Outclass will do the job well. Also remember that you could set rules in Outlook first, then install Outclass to work only as a spam filter. ☒